RESEARCHPAPER

Ireland's Layered Security Cooperation Model

How bilateral, EU, and NATO-adjacent cooperation tracks compound rather than compete — the institutional mechanics, the friction points, and the conditions under which this model is replicable for non-aligned EU member states.

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The Argument

The model

Ireland's security cooperation operates across three simultaneous tracks:

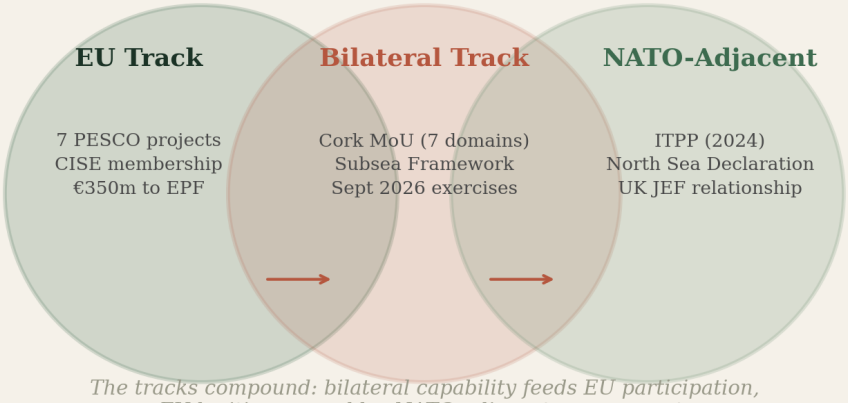
The EU track includes seven PESCO projects as full member (Maritime Surveillance Upgrade, Maritime Mine Countermeasures, Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection, Cyber Threats and Incident Response, Network of Logistic Hubs, plus two further projects), CISE membership for maritime data sharing since April 2025, and approximately €350 million committed to the European Peace Facility.

The bilateral track includes the Cork MoU signed March 2026 covering maritime, cyber, air domain, subsea, exercises, procurement, and training; the Subsea Infrastructure Framework for cable incident coordination; and joint exercises committed for September 2026.

The NATO-adjacent track includes the Individually Tailored Partnership Programme joined in 2024, the North Sea Joint Declaration application of March 2026, and a working relationship with the UK Joint Expeditionary Force.

The analytical claim is not simply that these tracks coexist, it is that they compound. Capability built through bilateral cooperation with the UK feeds directly into Ireland's EU framework participation. This feeding mechanism is specific and traceable, not metaphorical, and understanding how it works — and where it breaks down — is essential to making the model sustainable.

Three Cooperation Tracks



The tracks compound: bilateral capability feeds EU participation, EU legitimacy enables NATO-adjacent engagement.

The Institutional Mechanics of Capability Transfer

Maritime surveillance: from bilateral patrols to CISE data

The Cork MoU's maritime track establishes naval liaison and coordinated patrol operations between Irish and Royal Navy vessels in the shared maritime approach. When Irish vessels conduct joint patrols with UK assets, the surveillance data generated — vessel tracking, anomaly detection, subsurface acoustic data — feeds into the Irish Defence Forces' operational picture. Since April 2025, Ireland has been a CISE participant, meaning this data can be shared into the EU's Common Information Sharing Environment.

The transfer is not automatic; it passes through several institutional filters.

First, the **classification constraint**: data generated from joint UK patrols may carry UK classification markings that are not automatically shareable into EU systems. The practical protocols for downgrading or sanitising UK-origin maritime data for CISE ingestion do not yet exist.

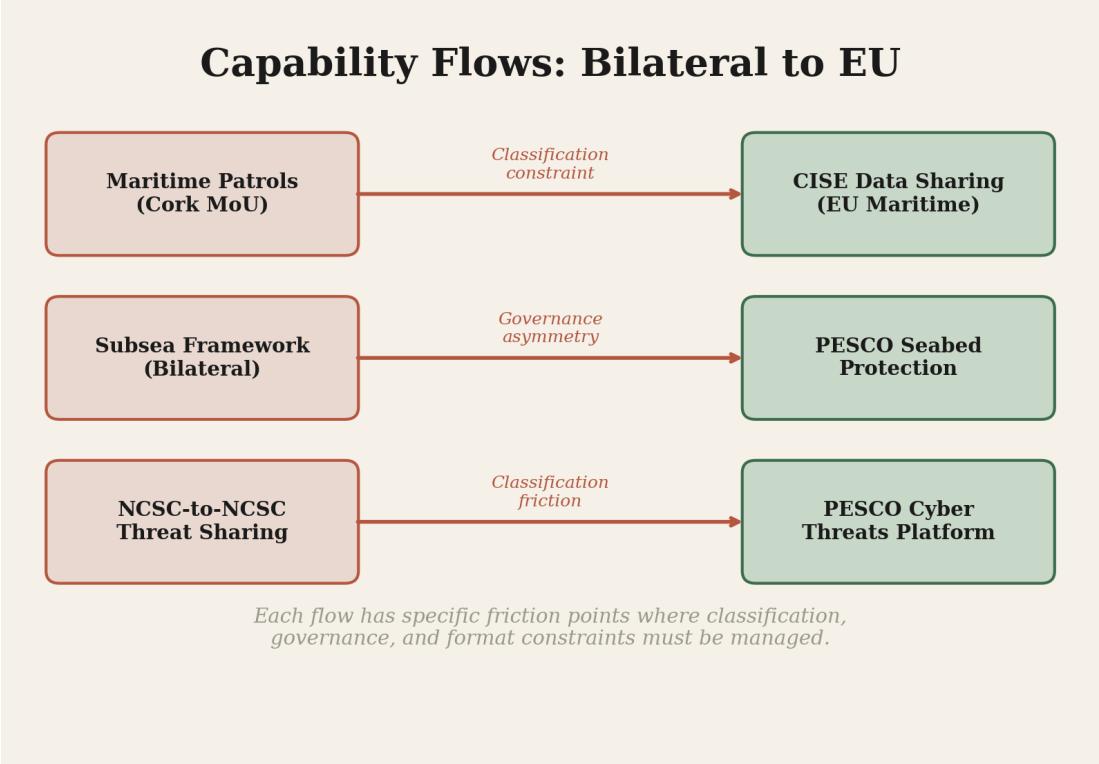
Second, the **format constraint**: UK maritime surveillance systems use different data standards than CISE's interoperability framework. Data reformatting requires dedicated integration capability within the Irish Defence Forces that does not currently exist at scale.

Subsea infrastructure: from bilateral framework to PESCO project

The Subsea Infrastructure Framework establishes coordinated response protocols for cable incidents in waters shared by Ireland and the UK. This operational protocol directly strengthens Ireland's contribution to the PESCO Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection project. The friction point is governance asymmetry: when an incident occurs in waters simultaneously covered by both frameworks, which governance takes precedence?

Cyber: from bilateral threat sharing to PESCO platform

The Cork MoU's cyber cooperation track establishes NCSC-to-NCSC threat intelligence sharing. The classification friction is most acute in the cyber domain. Ireland's NCSC must develop the institutional capacity to manage dual-track reporting: bilaterally sharing detailed indicators with the UK while sharing processed analysis with PESCO partners.


Capability Flows: Bilateral to EU
Maritime Patrols (Cork MoU)
Classification constraint
CISE Data Sharing (EU Maritime)
Subsea Framework (Bilateral)
Governance asymmetry
PESCO Seabed Protection
NCSC-to-NCSC Threat Sharing
Classification friction
PESCO Cyber Threats Platform
Each flow has specific friction points where classification, governance, and format constraints must be managed.

The Cork MoU: Anatomy and Gaps

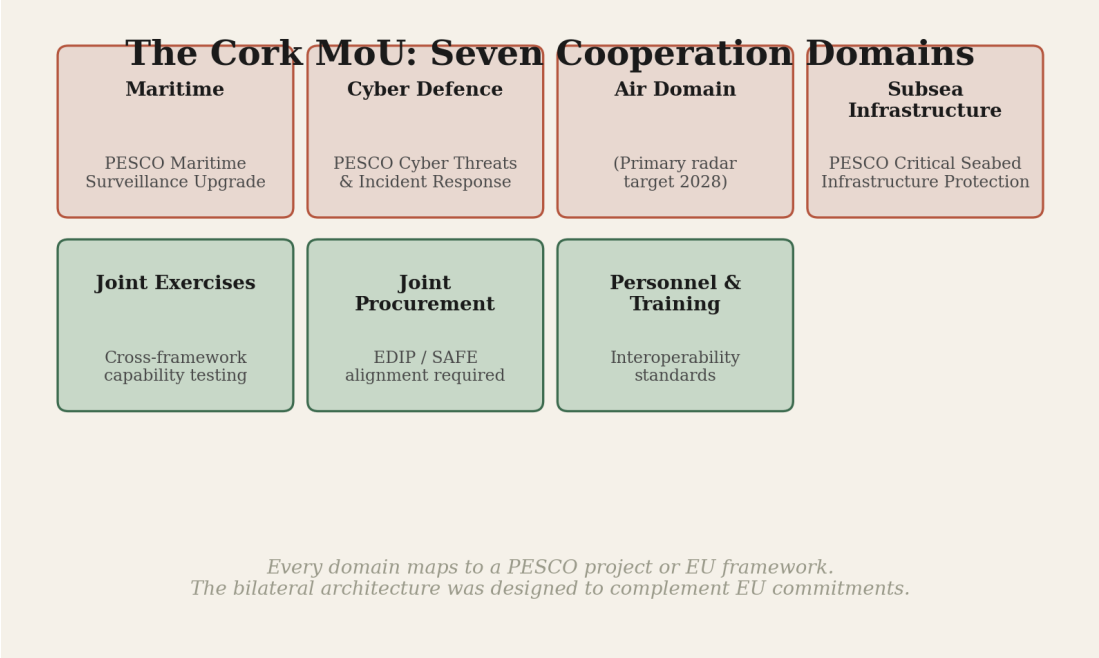
The Cork MoU covers seven domains: maritime, cyber defence, air domain information sharing, subsea infrastructure, joint exercises, joint procurement, and personnel/training exchanges. The design is deliberate: every domain maps to an existing PESCO project or EU framework.

But the MoU has three operational gaps that must be closed.

The air domain gap. The MoU commits to 'air domain information sharing' but does not address the secret RAF air intercept arrangement under which British fighters respond to unidentified aircraft in Irish airspace. Until Ireland has primary radar (target 2028), the bilateral air domain cooperation is structurally asymmetric.

The implementation gap. The MoU creates governance commitments at the London–Dublin level but has no mechanism for coordinating island-level operations. Subsea cables land on coasts in both jurisdictions, and the energy grid is coupled across the border.

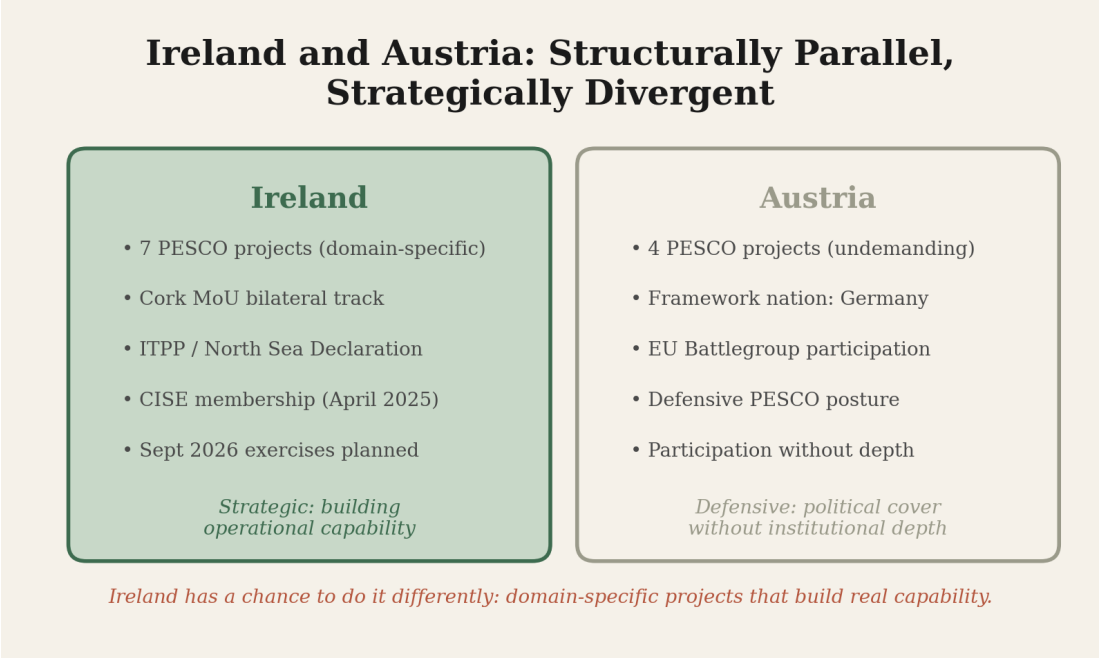
The procurement gap. The MoU commits to 'exploring joint procurement' but does not specify which platforms, under what terms, or through which frameworks. Joint procurement with a non-EU state requires careful alignment with EU procurement rules.



The Austrian Cautionary Tale

Austria provides both a parallel case and a warning. Like Ireland, Austria is an EU member, constitutionally neutral, and not a NATO member. Austria participates in PESCO with four projects. But Austria's approach to PESCO has been defensive, not strategic — choosing undemanding projects and contributing minimally. The result is participation that provides political cover without institutional depth.

Ireland risks the same outcome if layered cooperation remains at the governance level without generating operational capability. Seven PESCO projects on paper means nothing if those projects do not produce deployed capability that feeds into Ireland's maritime, subsea, and cyber domains.



The September 2026 Exercises as Design Problem

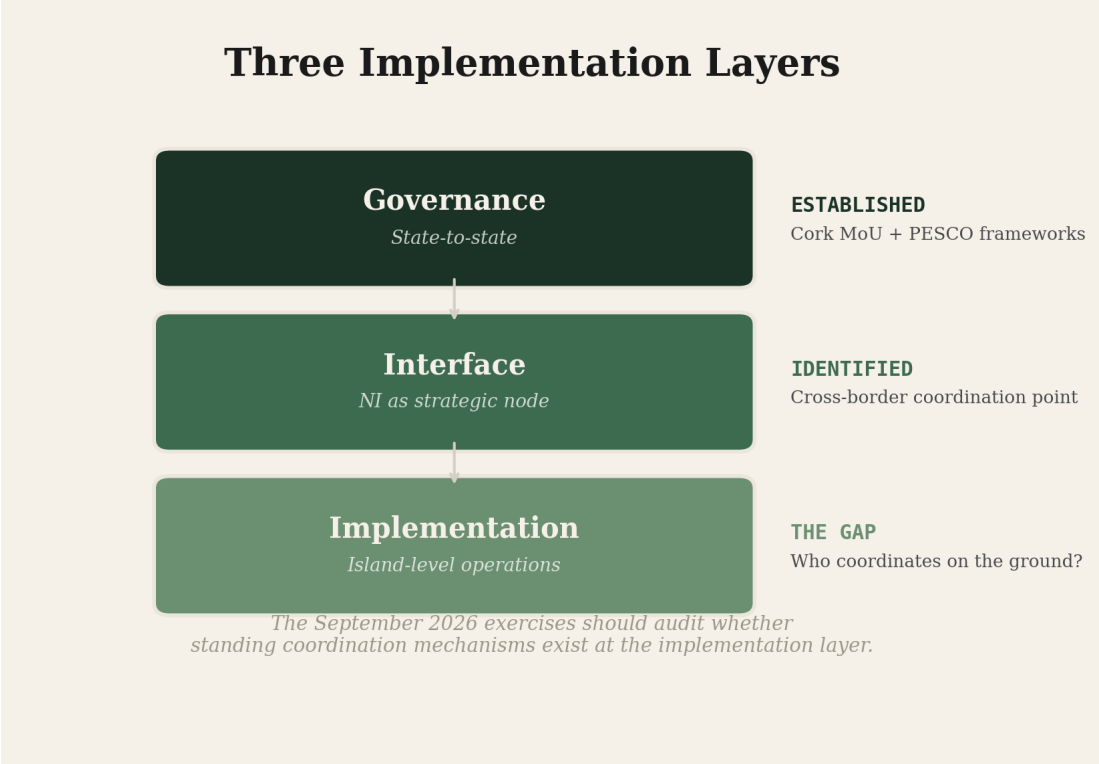
The joint exercises committed at Cork for September 2026 are the first opportunity to test whether the layered model generates operational capability or remains a governance exercise. The exercises should test five things:

> **(1) Classification transfer protocols.** Can maritime surveillance data from joint patrols be processed and shared into CISE within operational timelines?
>
> **(2) Dual-governance incident response.** When a subsea cable incident occurs in waters covered by both frameworks, which governance activates first?

(3) Cyber dual-track reporting. Can Ireland's NCSC simultaneously share detailed threat indicators bilaterally with UK NCSC and processed analysis with PESCO partners?

(4) Air domain asymmetry. How does air domain information sharing work when one partner has no independent detection capability?

(5) Cross-border coordination. Can island-level agencies in both jurisdictions coordinate a response to a simultaneous incident without ad hoc improvisation?



Conditions for Replicability

The layered cooperation model is replicable under five conditions:

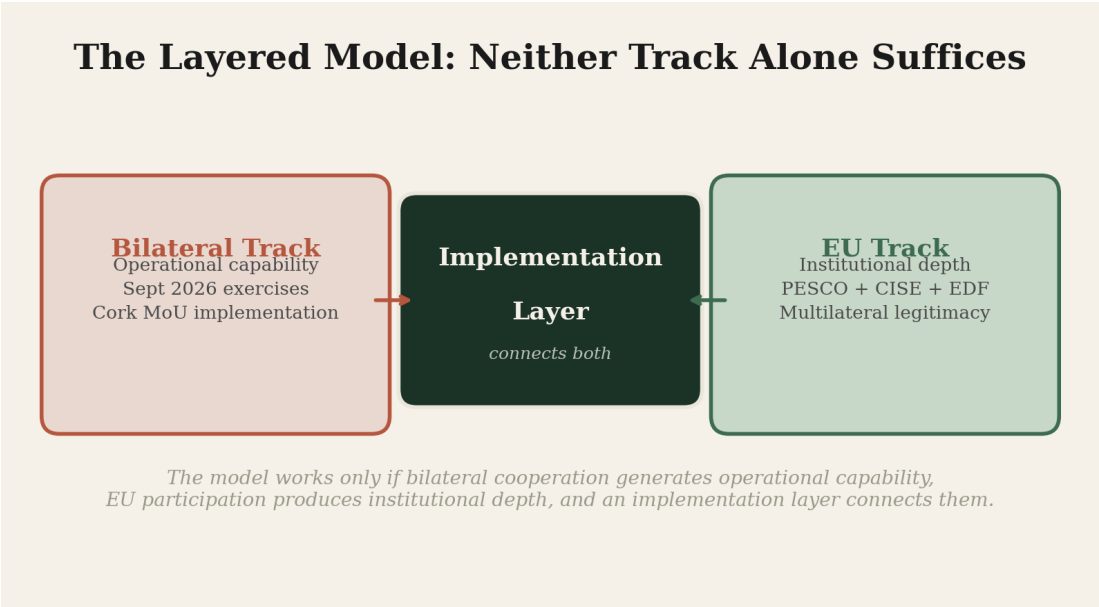
(1) Geographic domain relevance. The state must occupy a position that creates a specific security domain where its contribution is irreplaceable.

(2) An existing bilateral partner. The state must have a bilateral security relationship with a partner whose capabilities complement its own.

(3) EU framework access. The state must participate in PESCO and have access to EU funding instruments (EDF, EDIP, SAFE).

(4) NATO-adjacent engagement. Some form of engagement with NATO structures provides interoperability standards.

(5) Political capacity for the constitutional distinction. The state's political system must be capable of distinguishing between non-alignment and security cooperation.



Ireland's layered security cooperation model is analytically sound and practically validated by the Cork MoU, but it is not self-sustaining. The model works only if bilateral cooperation generates actual operational capability, EU participation produces institutional depth, and an implementation layer connects governance commitments to the island-level systems they are supposed to protect.